

INDEPENDENT M&E REVIEW

Nigeria's Adolescent Girls Initiative for Learning and Empowerment (AGILE)

What the Baseline Data Reveals About Programme Readiness, Household Conditions, and the Gaps in the Official Results Framework

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***Data Source:** AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), World Bank Microdata Library, public-use, anonymized*

Note on scope. This brief is a quantitative analysis of a three-state baseline dataset (Kaduna, Kano, Katsina). It does not attempt to explain the social meanings behind the patterns it documents; where the data speak to attitudes or norms, qualitative follow-up work is explicitly flagged for future study rather than inferred from survey responses.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Nigeria's Adolescent Girls Initiative for Learning and Empowerment (AGILE) is the largest gender-focused education investment in West African history, drawing on a combined US\$1.2 billion from the World Bank's International Development Association to improve secondary school access, life-skills training, and social-norm change for adolescent girls aged ten to twenty across eighteen Nigerian states. The programme's official Results Framework is anchored on enrolment counts, classroom construction tallies, and a binary measure of digital-literacy training completion. Those indicators matter. But this brief, the second in an independent M&E review series, demonstrates through primary analysis of the AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 that they capture far too little of the reality that determines whether a trained girl can use what she has been taught.

Four findings define this brief. First, at baseline, only one girl in six across the three surveyed states had ever used a mobile phone independently; fewer than one in seventeen had ever used a smartphone; and fewer than one in a hundred had ever touched a computer or tablet. Completing a digital-literacy training cycle does not become meaningful output until we know what prior exposure trainees had, yet the official Results Framework does not record it. Second, caregiver educational aspirations for daughters fall sharply as one moves northward across the three states: in Kaduna, more than half of caregivers aspire to a bachelor's degree or above; in Katsina, that share drops to under a third, with the modal aspiration shifting to a diploma or NCE certificate. Social-norm change is Component 2's most expensive intervention, but the Results Framework tracks no aspiration baseline against which to measure it. Third, one household in five across the sample has skipped meals in the past seven days, rising to one in four in Katsina; when food runs short, adult men forego meals most frequently, but girls are protected by the slimmest margin, a finding directly relevant to the financial-incentive sub-component, which is designed to reach the poorest households. No food-security indicator appears anywhere in the official framework. Fourth, while basic school infrastructure (water, toilets, blackboards) is present in most surveyed schools, only 26 per cent of those schools have sufficient classroom seats for their SS1 cohort, meaning three quarters of girls eligible for AGILE's academic programme have no seat in which to sit and learn. Infrastructure investment that adds classrooms without solving the seating shortage misses the binding constraint.

The brief concludes with five specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound indicator recommendations that AGILE should incorporate into its Results Framework before the midline survey, and with a closing argument that the four gaps identified here are not incidental omissions but structural blind spots in how the programme was designed to define success.

A methodological caveat runs through all four findings. The AGILE-IE Baseline is a large-N, structured survey instrument; it can show that caregiver aspirations differ across states, that households skip meals, and that digital exposure is thin, but it cannot tell us why caregivers choose "don't know," why some fathers go without food more often than mothers, or why particular girls never touch a smartphone. Interpreting those patterns requires qualitative methods – focus group discussions, in-depth interviews, and community narratives – that were outside the scope of this baseline. This brief therefore treats the quantitative findings as hypotheses for a future qualitative enquiry agenda, and explicitly signposts where such work is most urgently needed.

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1. PROGRAMME OVERVIEW

1.1 Origins and Rationale

The Adolescent Girls Initiative for Learning and Empowerment was approved by the World Bank's Board of Executive Directors on 1 July 2020 (Project P170664), drawing on an initial International Development Association credit of US\$500 million, the single largest IDA-financed education project in Nigerian history at the time of approval (World Bank, 2020). The project was conceived in response to a compound crisis in Nigerian girls' secondary education that had been documented across multiple preceding data cycles: an estimated 7.4 million adolescent girls out of school nationally (World Bank PAD, 2020), a national Human Capital Index of 0.34 (2018), a gross secondary enrolment gender-parity index of 0.952 at national level but substantially lower in the predominantly Muslim north-west and north-east zones, and pupil-to-toilet ratios in public schools reaching as high as 280 to 1 in the project's target geography (ESMF, 2019).

The Federal Ministry of Education (FME) serves as implementing agency, operating through a National Project Coordinating Unit (NPCU) at the federal level and State Project Implementation Units (SPIUs) in each participating state. President Muhammadu Buhari officially flagged off the project on 16 February 2023 following a period of mobilization, procurement, and systems establishment (AGILE Project Website, 2023).

1.2 Project Architecture

AGILE operates through three interlocking components:

Component 1, Creating Safe and Accessible Learning Spaces addresses the supply side of secondary education access. Its principal instruments are school construction grants (School Improvement Grants, or SIGs) targeting new Junior Secondary School and Senior Secondary School classrooms, sanitation facilities, and water infrastructure; teacher recruitment and deployment; and the rehabilitation of existing school buildings. By April 2023, the project had renovated or newly constructed more than 5,000 classrooms project-wide and installed in excess of 8,400 toilets across participating states (FME, April 2023). In Sokoto State alone, one of the states added in the 2023 Additional Financing, 749 classrooms were renovated and 214 solar-powered boreholes sunk by early 2025 (Gazette NG, 2025).

Component 2, Fostering an Enabling Environment addresses the demand side and the social-norm architecture surrounding girls' education. It encompasses: a national communication campaign operating under the "Madubi" brand identity, developed in Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo and disseminated through broadcast media, digital platforms, and celebrity ambassadors; advocacy with traditional and religious leaders; life-skills and digital-literacy training targeting approximately 850,000 girls in the original project scope; and financial incentive payments, effectively conditional scholarships, directed at the poorest enrolled households to offset opportunity costs of schooling. The financial-incentive sub-component alone was designed to reach approximately 350,000 beneficiary households at inception (FME/World Bank, February 2021).

Component 3, Project Management and System Strengthening provides the institutional infrastructure for implementation: technical assistance, monitoring and evaluation, the Grievance Redress Mechanism (GRM), environmental and social safeguard management, and capacity building at both federal and state levels.

1.3 Scale-Up: The 2023 Additional Financing

On 22 September 2023, the World Bank Board approved Additional Financing of US\$700 million (SDR 521.3 million) under project P179281, expanding the programme from its original seven states, Borno, Ekiti, Kaduna, Kano, Katsina, Kebbi, and Plateau, to eighteen states by adding Adamawa, Bauchi, Gombe, Jigawa, Kogi, Nasarawa, Niger, Sokoto, Yobe, Zamfara, and the Federal Capital Territory (World Bank, 2023). The scale-up also broadened the eligible beneficiary population to include out-of-school girls,

married adolescents, and girls with disabilities, groups that the original project design had not explicitly targeted. The revised combined target stands at 8.6 million direct girl beneficiaries, with 21.5 million projected direct and indirect beneficiaries over the project lifetime (TheCable, 2023). As of June 2025, total disbursement across both tranches stood at US\$368.87 million, approximately 31 per cent of the US\$1.2 billion envelope, with the Project Development Objective and Implementation Progress both rated Moderately Satisfactory (World Bank Implementation Review Mission, June 2025).

1.4 Governance and Accountability Concerns

Not all reporting on AGILE has been positive, and a complete programme overview demands acknowledgement of documented implementation challenges. In July 2023, Kebbi State's AGILE project was suspended by the state government following the uncovering of N8.8 billion in unauthorized procurement contracts; three senior state officials were dismissed (The Guardian Nigeria, 2023). A June 2024 implementation review noted that insecurity in several participating states, particularly in the north-east, which includes Borno, had delayed construction timelines and site access sufficiently to prompt the World Bank to mandate the engagement of a dedicated security consultancy (The Guardian Nigeria, 2024). A November 2025 field visit to Kebbi documented abandoned, half-completed school structures along the Gwandu axis, with local officials attributing the stall to unresolved payment pipeline disputes (Punch Newspapers, 2025). A third-party monitoring review by Connected Development (CODE) raised concerns about contractor vetting and adherence to structural specifications across more than 2,500 active school sites (CODE, 2023).

These issues do not negate AGILE's substantial enrolment and infrastructure achievements. They do underscore the importance of rigorous baseline documentation and a Results Framework that is capable of detecting implementation quality shortfalls alongside output counts, a capability this brief will argue the current framework partially lacks.

1.5 The Analytical Focus of Brief 2

This brief draws on the AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023, a pre-implementation survey commissioned to establish comparison points for the programme's impact evaluation, to examine four dimensions of programme readiness and household context that the official Results Framework does not currently capture: digital prior experience among training cohorts, the distribution of caregiver educational aspirations across states, household food insecurity as a proxy for beneficiary poverty depth, and the adequacy of classroom seating as a binding infrastructure constraint. Each of these dimensions bears directly on whether AGILE's principal interventions, digital-literacy training, social-norm change, financial incentives, and school construction, will achieve their intended effects.

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Data Source

This brief draws on the AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023, formally catalogued as NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M in the World Bank Microdata Library. The dataset is public-use and anonymized. It was collected prior to the roll-out of AGILE programme activities in the sampled schools and is the primary quantitative instrument for the programme's impact evaluation, conducted in partnership with Innovations for Poverty Action (IPA). The microdata catalogue record confirms that data collection covered three of the seven original AGILE participating states: Kaduna, Kano, and Katsina.

The analysis presented in this brief uses three constituent sub-datasets from the survey:

- Adolescent survey (N = 8,223 girls; 898 variables): The primary respondent dataset, capturing digital experience, household food security, aspirations, and background characteristics for enrolled SS1 adolescent girls.
- Caregiver survey (N = 8,007 caregivers; 329 variables): Capturing household socioeconomic status, educational aspirations for the adolescent, and food security indicators, from the primary adult guardian of each surveyed girl.
- School survey (N = 270 schools; 52 variables): Capturing facility-level data on infrastructure, classroom counts and seating capacity, toilet provision, water access, and teaching resources.

Row counts were verified against published dataset documentation: the adolescent file's 8,223 rows and 897 content variables (one additional column carries the state name appended during analysis) match the published metadata exactly. State distribution in the adolescent file is: Katsina 3,345; Kano 2,610; Kaduna 2,268.

2.2 Analytical Approach

All analyses were conducted in Python 3.10 using pandas for data manipulation, NumPy for array operations, and Matplotlib for visualization. The analytical workflow proceeded as follows:

1. Variable identification and coding verification. Binary items (e.g., "ever used a mobile phone," "classroom has a blackboard") were confirmed as 0/1 encoded from the variable description files. Ordinal aspiration items were mapped to named categories using the codebook's value-label dictionaries. Food-insecurity items were recoded from a 1-4 frequency scale (1 = rarely, 2 = sometimes, 3 = often, 4 = always), with any response coded -555 treated as valid missing and excluded from the denominator for the frequency analysis.
2. Descriptive percentages by state. For each item, the proportion of respondents reporting the affirmative outcome was computed separately for each of the three states and for the pooled sample using pandas `.mean()` on the binary column, then multiplied by 100 to express as a percentage.
3. Visualization. Four publication-quality charts were produced at 180 DPI and saved as PNG files. Chart palettes use the color scheme established in Brief 1 (Navy #1a3a5c, Gold #c89b3c, Teal #3b7d7d, Grey #7a7a7a).
4. Key-findings export. A companion CSV (`key_findings_numbers.csv`) was exported containing 83 rows of analysis-tagged, state-disaggregated findings for use in the data appendix of this brief.

2.3 Limitations

Four limitations apply to all findings in Section 4 and should be held in mind throughout:

- Scope limitation. The three states analyzed, Kaduna, Kano, and Katsina, represent three of the seven original AGILE states and none of the eleven states added in the 2023 Additional Financing. Findings characterize the northern-bloc context but should not be extrapolated to southern states (Ekiti, Plateau) or to the expanded geographic footprint.

- Enrolment selection. All survey respondents are SS1 girls already enrolled in 270 selected AGILE-area schools. The most marginalized adolescents, out-of-school girls, girls in informal Qur'anic education, girls who never enrolled, are systematically absent from the sample. Digital-exposure levels and food-security prevalence among enrolled girls likely represent upper bounds relative to the full target population.
- Cross-sectional baseline. The dataset captures conditions prior to programme contact. The brief characterizes starting conditions and gaps in programme-readiness measurement. It does not assess programme impact, which requires a comparison design and is the purpose of the ongoing impact evaluation.
- Self-report caveats. All measures are collected through computer-assisted personal interview (CAPI). Social-desirability pressures may affect responses to sensitive items, most obviously food insecurity (under-reporting possible) and digital-device access (over-reporting for devices associated with social status).
- Qualitative blind spot. The baseline was designed as a structured survey. It does not include open-ended questions, focus group transcripts, or interview narratives. As a result, any interpretation of **why** caregivers express particular aspirations, or **why** households allocate food as they do, would be speculative. This brief deliberately avoids ascribing motives and instead treats the quantitative patterns as prompts for qualitative follow-up work.

3. STATED INDICATORS AND TARGETS

3.1 The Project Development Objective

The Project Development Objective (PDO) of AGILE is stated verbatim in the Project Appraisal Document (World Bank, July 2020, Project P170664) as:

"To improve secondary education opportunities among girls in targeted areas in participating states."

This formulation is deliberately broad. "Opportunities" encompasses enrolment, infrastructure, life skills, financial access, and social enabling conditions simultaneously. The breadth is a design choice, it allows the programme to claim multiple pathways to a single development goal, but it also creates a measurement burden: a PDO this wide requires a Results Framework sufficiently comprehensive to triangulate progress across all contributing pathways. The analysis in Section 5 of this brief will argue that the existing framework does not meet that triangulation requirement.

3.2 The Official Results Framework: Indicator Families

The AGILE Results Framework, as specified in the PAD Annex 1 and updated for the Additional Financing (World Bank, 2023), organizes its indicators into four families.

Indicator	Baseline	Year 5 Target	Data Source
Girls benefiting from direct project interventions (number)	0	6,000,000	MIS / Admin
Girls currently enrolled in JSS and SSS in participating states (number)	~900,000 (2020)	1,692,000	EMIS
Girls transitioning from JSS to SSS (percentage)	Varies by state	60%	School surveys
Girls completing AGILE life-skills programme (number)	0	340,000	MIS / Admin
Students trained who demonstrate digital literacy (percentage)	n/a	55%	Post-training assessment
JSS constructed or substantially rehabilitated (number)	0	400	Civil works progress reports
SSS constructed or substantially rehabilitated (number)	0	260	Civil works progress reports
Beneficiaries receiving financial incentive payments (number)	0	350,000	MIS / Admin
Schools with functioning SBMC trained on safeguarding (number)	Varies	16,000	School surveys
Grievances registered and resolved within stipulated timeframes (percentage)	n/a	>=95%	GRM Logbooks

Sources: World Bank PAD (P170664, 2020); FME/World Bank Additional Financing documentation (P179281, 2023); FME Project Implementation Manual (2021).

Coverage and enrolment indicators (rows 1-3 above) measure how many girls are reached by the programme or enrolled in secondary school. They are the framework's headline accountability metrics and are directly linked to the PDO. As of May 2023, over three million girls had been enrolled in secondary schools under AGILE's active states (TheCable, 2023), substantially exceeding the Year 3 milestone, a significant achievement worth noting before the analytical critique that follows.

Life-skills and training output indicators (rows 4-5) measure completion of, and demonstrated competence from, the digital-literacy and life-skills training programmes delivered under Component 2.

The digital-literacy indicator targets 55 per cent of trained girls demonstrating competence in a post-training assessment. This is a well-specified output indicator. What is missing is an input indicator characterizing the digital experience that trainees bring to the programme, a point this brief returns to in Section 4.

Infrastructure output indicators (rows 6-7) measure numbers of classrooms constructed or rehabilitated. They count rooms built; they do not measure whether those rooms have sufficient seats, functioning electricity, or access to appropriate learning materials. This distinction becomes important in the context of Finding 4 (Section 4.4).

Financial-incentive and social-mobilization indicators (rows 8-9) track payment delivery to households and training of School-Based Management Committees. They measure process fidelity, whether incentives reach households and whether committees are trained, but not whether households receiving incentives are truly the most food-insecure among eligible families, or whether caregiver aspirations have shifted after SBMC engagement.

Accountability indicators (row 10) track GRM functionality. This is good M&E practice and reflects the comprehensive GRM architecture described in the Grievance Redress Mechanism Manual (FME, 2022), which establishes a three-tier committee structure, dedicated GBV protocols, and quarterly reporting to the World Bank Task Team Leader.

3.3 What the Framework Does Not Measure

Five categories of information relevant to AGILE's theory of change are absent from the published Results Framework:

- Pre-training digital exposure of trainees. Without a baseline on device experience and internet access, the 55 per cent competency-demonstration target cannot be contextualized: was it achieved because the programme was effective, or because trainees were already digitally literate?
- Caregiver educational aspirations. Component 2's social-norm change investments have no baseline aspiration indicator against which to measure movement.
- Household food security. The financial-incentive sub-component targets the poorest households, but no household-level food-security indicator anchors the targeting verification.
- Classroom seating adequacy. Construction indicators count rooms; they do not measure whether physical learning capacity matches enrolled cohort size.
- Gender-differentiated intra-household resource allocation. When resources are scarce in beneficiary households, who bears the cost, boys or girls, adults or children? This information is critical for understanding whether financial incentives change household dynamics for adolescent girls specifically.

The evidence for each of these gaps is taken up in Section 4, using the AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 as the analytical lens.

4. FINDINGS FROM THE BASELINE DATA

4.1 Finding 1: The Digital Literacy Floor, Very Few AGILE-Area Girls Have Prior Device Experience

4.1.1 What Was Measured

The adolescent survey contains nine binary items capturing whether the respondent has ever used each of nine digital devices or services: mobile phone, internet, online search, initiated a digital transaction, smartphone, shopped online, online banking, computer, and tablet. These items map directly onto the device categories targeted by AGILE's digital-literacy training curriculum under Component 2.

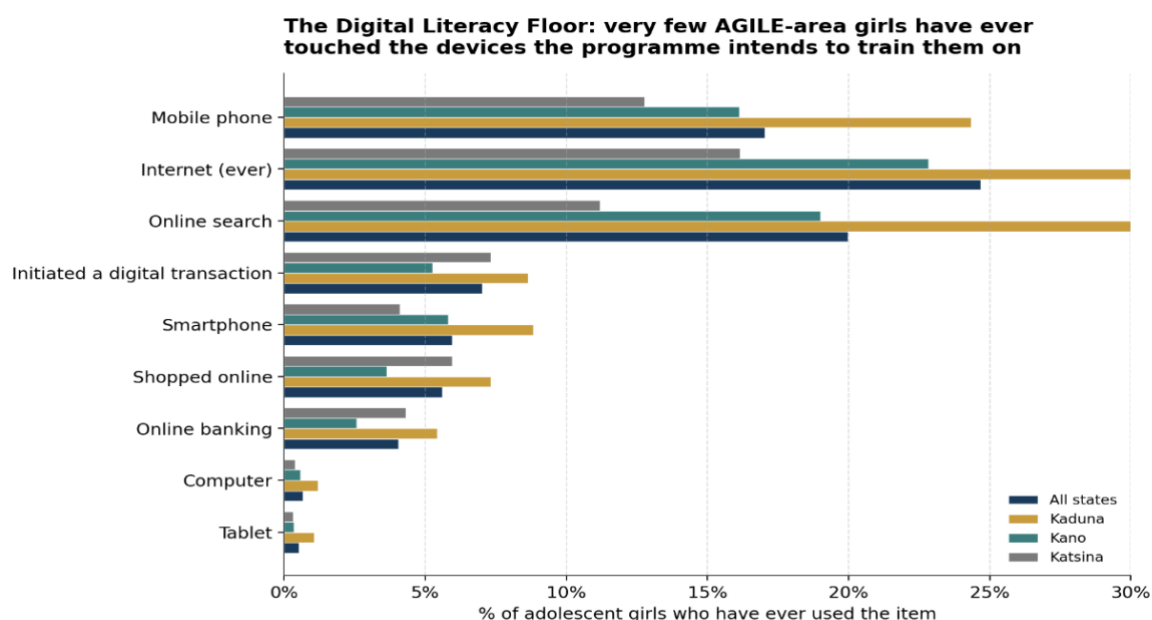
4.1.2 Results

Table 4.1, Percentage of SS1 Adolescent Girls Who Have Ever Used Each Device or Service, by State (AGILE-IE Baseline 2023)

Device / Service	Kaduna (%)	Kano (%)	Katsina (%)	All States (%)
Mobile phone	24.34	16.13	12.77	17.03
Internet (ever)	39.42	22.84	16.14	24.69
Online search	34.04	19.00	11.18	19.97
Initiated a digital transaction	8.64	5.25	7.32	7.03
Smartphone	8.82	5.82	4.10	5.95
Shopped online	7.32	3.64	5.95	5.59
Online banking	5.42	2.57	4.30	4.06
Computer	1.19	0.57	0.39	0.67
Tablet	1.06	0.34	0.33	0.54

Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), N = 8,223.

Figure 1. The digital literacy floor: % of SS1 adolescent girls who have ever used each digital device or service, by state (N = 8,223).



Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (World Bank, NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M).

The headline figure is stark: across all three states, the overwhelming majority of enrolled SS1 girls have had no prior experience with any digital device or online service. The computer penetration rate is below 1 per cent nationally. Smartphone penetration is under 6 per cent. Even the most basic digital device, a mobile phone, has been used by only 17 per cent of girls. The northward gradient is pronounced: Kaduna girls, at 24.34 per cent, are nearly twice as likely to have used a mobile phone as Katsina girls, at 12.77 per cent. For internet access, the Kaduna-Katsina gap widens to a 2.5-times advantage.

4.1.3 M&E Implication

The official framework's digital-literacy indicator measures the percentage of trained girls who demonstrate competency after training. That is a legitimate outcome indicator. What it cannot show is whether the 55 per cent competency target reflects genuine programme-induced learning or a selection effect: girls who were already digitally familiar before training are disproportionately in the training cohort, while the most digitally excluded girls either self-select out of training or fall below the competency threshold because their starting point was near zero. The baseline data in Table 4.1 quantify the exposure landscape. A pre-training intake form that records prior device experience for each trainee cohort would provide the denominator that transforms the post-training competency indicator from a simple output count into a genuine learning-gain metric.

The structured survey design, with its fixed response categories, can show the pattern of low digital exposure across states, but cannot tell us how girls and caregivers *feel* about digital skills, whether sceptical households, cost-constrained families, or families actively restricting daughters' device use due to perceived moral risk are driving these patterns, or how girls themselves weigh digital literacy's promises against everyday realities like time poverty or safety concerns. Interpreting these patterns requires qualitative methods - focus group discussions, in-depth interviews, and community narratives - that were outside the scope of this baseline.

4.1.4 Cross-State Pattern

The northward gradient in digital exposure deserves separate attention. Kaduna's advantage over Katsina is not marginal: internet access is 2.5 times higher (39 per cent versus 16 per cent); mobile-phone experience is twice as common (24 per cent versus 13 per cent). A single national digital-literacy curriculum, delivered in a standardized way across all three states, will produce dramatically different competency outcomes not because of differences in programme quality but because of differences in the starting-point cohort. State-differentiated baseline digital-exposure tracking is therefore a prerequisite for any fair state-to-state comparison of training outcomes.

4.1.5 Qualitative Questions the Numbers Cannot Answer

The baseline can show that most girls in AGILE states have almost no prior device experience and that internet access falls sharply moving north, but it cannot tell us how girls and caregivers *feel* about digital skills. Are low-exposure households sceptical of online spaces, constrained by cost, or actively restricting daughters' device use because of perceived moral risk? Nor can the survey reveal how girls themselves weigh the promises of digital literacy against everyday realities like time poverty or safety.

A logical next step is a round of structured focus group discussions (FGDs) with:

- SS1 girls in high- and low-exposure schools; and
- Caregivers in communities at both ends of the digital gradient.

Discussion guides should explore perceived risks and benefits of phones and internet use, intra-household rules around device sharing, and what "successful" digital training would mean in girls' own terms. These qualitative insights would help interpret the baseline numbers and refine the design of the Component 2 digital-literacy curriculum.

4.2 Finding 2: The Caregiver Aspiration Gradient, Educational Expectations for Daughters Fall Sharply Moving North

4.2.1 What Was Measured

The caregiver survey contains a variable capturing the highest level of education the caregiver aspires for the adolescent girl in their household (variable aa2_3_lvl_constrnt_educ). Response options span from "none" through "primary," "junior secondary," "senior secondary (SS3)," "vocational/TVET,"

"diploma/NCE," "bachelor's degree," "master's degree," "doctorate," and "other/don't know." The variable was grouped into four analytical bands for visualization: "up to SS3 only" (combining responses 1-5); "vocational/diploma" (responses 6-7); "bachelor's degree" (response 8); and "master's or higher" (responses 9-10), with a residual "other/don't know" category.

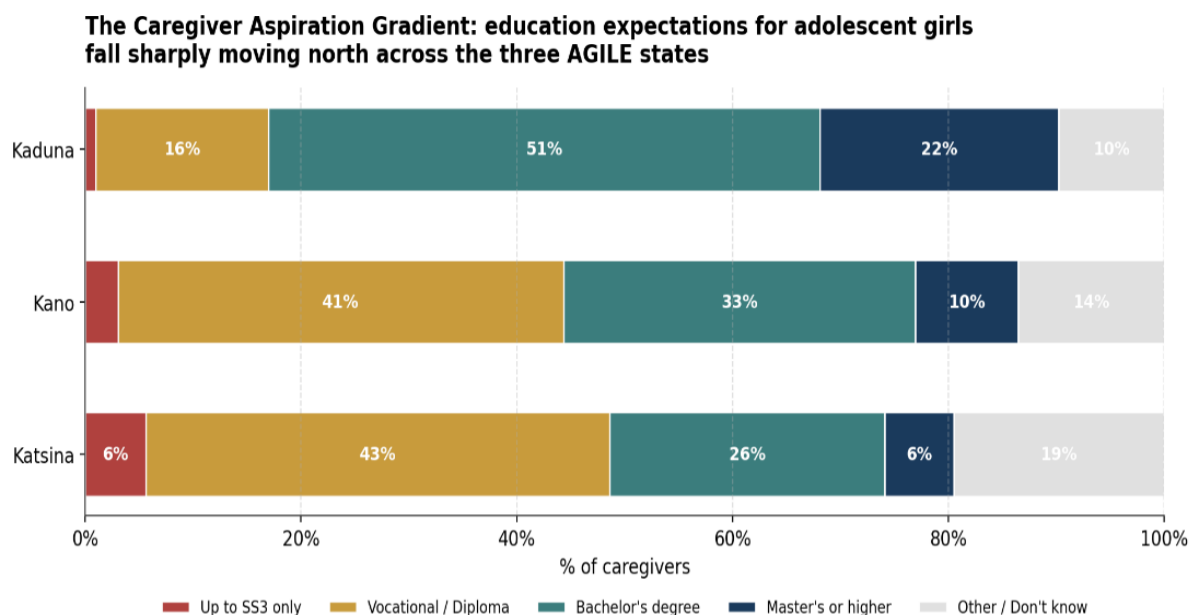
4.2.2 Results

Table 4.2, Caregiver Educational Aspirations for Adolescent Daughters, by State (AGILE-IE Baseline 2023)

Aspiration Level	Kaduna (%)	Kano (%)	Katsina (%)
None	0.05	0.08	0.46
Primary	0.18	0.04	0.00
Junior secondary	0.14	0.16	0.28
Senior secondary (SS3)	0.55	2.75	4.89
Vocational/TVET	2.94	1.32	1.07
Diploma/NCE	13.10	39.99	41.88
Bachelor's degree	51.10	32.62	25.54
Master's degree	17.88	8.29	4.53
Doctorate	4.27	1.24	1.87
Other/Don't know	9.79	13.52	19.49

Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), N = 8,007 caregivers.

Figure 2. The caregiver aspiration gradient: distribution of caregiver educational aspirations for adolescent daughters, by state (N = 8,007).



Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (World Bank, NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M).

The data reveal a pronounced aspiration gradient across the three states. In Kaduna, the modal response is "bachelor's degree" at 51 per cent, with a further 22 per cent of caregivers aspiring to master's-level or doctoral education. The proportion of Kaduna caregivers whose aspirations for their daughters extend to bachelor's level or above reaches 73 per cent. In Kano, the modal response shifts: "diploma/NCE" is the most common at 40 per cent, with "bachelor's degree" at 33 per cent, still a substantial higher-education aspiration, but notably lower than Kaduna. In Katsina, diploma/NCE remains the mode at 42 per cent, while the bachelor's-degree share drops further to 26 per cent. Doctoral aspirations in Katsina (1.87 per cent) are less than half the Kaduna level (4.27 per cent).

Equally notable is the "other/don't know" category, which captures either genuine uncertainty about educational pathways or ambivalence about articulating aspirations to a survey interviewer. This

response climbs from 10 per cent in Kaduna to 20 per cent in Katsina, suggesting that roughly one Katsina caregiver in five either has not formed a stable aspiration for their daughter's educational trajectory or does not feel confident enough in that aspiration to name it. Whether this represents a cultural norm, a household uncertainty, or a social-desirability effect of under-stating ambition to a stranger is not determinable from the survey alone, but the proportion is large enough to warrant dedicated qualitative investigation.

The 20 per cent "other/don't know" response in Katsina is a textbook example of a quantitative pattern that demands qualitative exploration. Short semi-structured FGDs with mothers, fathers, and grandmothers in high-"don't know" communities could probe:

- how caregivers describe "a good life" for daughters in their own words;
- where secondary and post-secondary schooling fits into that narrative; and
- which actors (religious leaders, peers, husbands, employers) shape those views.

Such work would help distinguish genuine uncertainty (caregivers unfamiliar with education pathways) from constrained aspiration (caregivers who would like more schooling but expect early marriage) and from interview dynamics (caregivers cautious about expressing ambition to an outsider). Without that nuance, any movement in the aspiration percentages at midline will be difficult to interpret.

4.2.3 M&E Implication

Component 2 of AGILE explicitly invests in social-norm change: the Madubi communication campaign, advocacy through traditional rulers and religious leaders, school-based life-skills sessions, and community-level dialogue on the value of secondary and post-secondary education for girls. The June 2025 Implementation Review Mission notes that three of the five Year 5 PDO targets have been achieved or surpassed, but it does not specify whether any of those three relate to aspiration-level change, because no aspiration indicator exists in the Results Framework.

This is a significant accountability gap. Component 2 is not a small sub-component: it encompasses one of the costliest elements of a US\$1.2 billion programme. Its theory of change rests on the proposition that communication, advocacy, and life-skills training shift the beliefs of families and communities about the appropriate level of education for adolescent girls. The baseline data presented here provide the first rigorous evidence of what that aspiration landscape looks like before programme contact in three states. Without a midline and endline measurement of the same aspiration variable, using the same response categories, no evidence will exist that Component 2 achieved the norm shift it was designed to produce.

4.2.4 The Northward Gradient and Programme Differentiation

The aspiration gradient documented here has programmatic as well as evaluative implications. AGILE's communication campaign and advocacy strategy appear to operate through a single national "Madubi" brand identity deployed in Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo across all states. The baseline data suggest that the aspiration landscape in Katsina, where a diploma-level ceiling is the modal caregiver expectation and one in five caregivers has no stable aspiration for their daughter, is substantially different from the landscape in Kaduna, where more than half of caregivers already aspire to a university degree. A norm-change communication strategy that is calibrated for the Kaduna environment, where the task is to shift a diploma aspiration to a degree aspiration, will not be appropriately calibrated for a Katsina environment, where the task is to establish and strengthen the proposition that girls should finish secondary school at all.

Without state-level aspiration baselines, programme managers have no basis on which to differentiate communication strategy by state. With those baselines, now available from this dataset, that differentiation becomes possible.

4.3 Finding 3: Household Food Insecurity, One Household in Five Has Skipped Meals in the Past Seven Days

4.3.1 What Was Measured

The caregiver survey contains a set of items adapted from the Household Food Insecurity Access Scale (HFIAS) asking about meal-skipping and food shortfalls in the past seven days. The primary item (fs_1_skip_meal) captures whether the household has skipped any meal in the past seven days (binary: 1 = yes). A follow-up item set (fs_3a_adultmen, fs_3b_adultwomen, fs_3c_boys, fs_3d_girls) captures, for households that skipped meals, the frequency with which each household-member category goes without food when supplies run short, on a four-point scale (1 = rarely, 2 = sometimes, 3 = often, 4 = always). Responses coded -555 (not applicable, because the household has no member of that type) were treated as valid missing values and excluded from the denominator for the frequency analysis.

4.3.2 Results: Prevalence of Meal-Skipping by State

Table 4.3, Percentage of Households Reporting Any Meal Skipped in the Past Seven Days, by State

State	% Households Skipping Meals
Kaduna	21.72
Kano	12.63
Katsina	26.94
All states (pooled)	~20

Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), N = 8,007 caregivers.

Approximately one in five households across the pooled sample has experienced meal shortfalls in the preceding week. Katsina records the highest prevalence at 27 per cent, more than one in four households. Kano has the lowest at 13 per cent, while Kaduna sits at 22 per cent. These figures describe households in which an enrolled SS1 girl is present, and from which a caregiver responded to the survey; they do not capture out-of-school or non-enrolled households, where food insecurity is almost certainly higher.

4.3.3 Results: Who Bears the Cost When Food is Short

Among the approximately 1,600 households that reported meal-skipping, the frequency with which each household-member category goes without food when supplies run short reveals a distinctive and policy-relevant intra-household pattern.

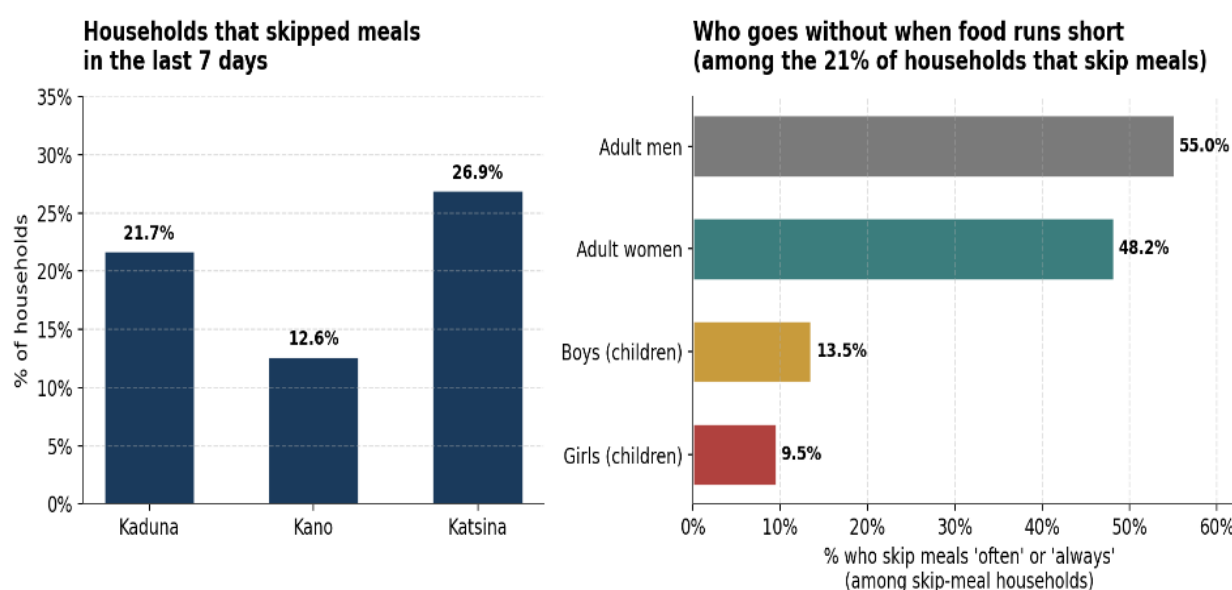
Table 4.4, Percentage of Meal-Skipping Households Reporting "Often" or "Always" Going Without Food, by Member Category

Household Member Category	% Reporting "Often" or "Always"
Adult men	55.04
Adult women	48.18
Boys (children)	13.52
Girls (children)	9.55

Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), restricted to households reporting meal-skipping (N approx 1,600).

Figure 3. Household food insecurity in the AGILE-IE sample: (A) % of households reporting any meal-skipping in past 7 days, by state; (N = 8,007). (B) frequency of meal-skipping by household member type among skip-meal households. (N = 1,600).

Household Food Insecurity in the AGILE-IE Sample



Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (World Bank, NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M).

The hierarchy is counterintuitive in direction but significant in magnitude. Adult men and women bear the heaviest burden of chronic food shortfall: more than half of meal-skipping households report that adult men often or always go without food when supplies are short, with adult women close behind at 48 per cent. Children, both boys and girls, experience meal shortfalls less frequently, suggesting a household norm of child-first food prioritization.

However, among children, girls (9.55 per cent) are protected less than boys (13.52 per cent). That 4-percentage-point difference may appear modest, but in a sample of 1,600 meal-skipping households it represents a meaningful differential: girls are somewhat more exposed to food shortfalls than boys even within households that express a general child-prioritization norm. The magnitude of this difference is consistent with the broader literature on intra-household gender-differentiated resource allocation in rural northern Nigeria (GBV Assessment Report, FME, 2020). Qualitative work conducted for the AGILE GBV Assessment in 2020 already documents caregivers describing daughters' phone use as "both a blessing and a temptation," and reports of girls being withdrawn from school after rumours of inappropriate online communication (Dirisu, 2020). Those narratives are consistent with the low-exposure baseline documented here and underscore the need for structured FGDs on digital norms before scaling Component 2's curriculum.

4.3.4 M&E Implication

AGILE's financial-incentive sub-component is designed explicitly to reach the poorest enrolled households. The programme documentation describes it as targeting families where the opportunity cost of keeping a daughter in school is highest, defined operationally in terms of household poverty and vulnerability. Two accountability questions follow naturally: First, are the households actually receiving incentive payments among the most food-insecure? Second, when incentives reach households, do they reduce food insecurity for the adolescent girl specifically?

Neither question can be answered from the current Results Framework. The incentive delivery indicator (Table 3.1, row 8) counts the number of payments made. It does not record the food-security status of recipient households before or after payment. The absence of a food-security targeting indicator means that the programme cannot demonstrate in its own reporting that its financial

incentives are reaching the households with the greatest need, as opposed to the households with the greatest administrative accessibility or the most organized SBMC relationships.

The HFIAS items in the baseline survey provide exactly the baseline food-security scores that would allow this targeting verification. Were those scores appended to each household's administrative record in the MIS, they would allow the programme to demonstrate at midline both that incentive payments reached food-insecure households and that those households' food-security situation improved relative to a matched control group.

4.3.5 Intersecting Vulnerabilities

The combination of Findings 2 and 3 is particularly revealing. Katsina is simultaneously the state with the lowest caregiver educational aspirations, the highest household food-insecurity prevalence, and the widest gap between girls' and boys' exposure to intra-household food shortfalls. This intersection is not coincidental: the literature on girls' education in northern Nigeria consistently identifies poverty-driven hawking, food insecurity, and low parental aspiration as co-occurring and mutually reinforcing barriers (GBV Assessment Report, FME, 2020; Odigbo Iji, January 2025). A programme Results Framework that captures none of these dimensions cannot distinguish the states and communities where multiple barriers cluster from those where only one barrier is operative, which is precisely the information that state-level resource allocation decisions require.

4.3.6 Qualitative Enquiry on Intra-Household Bargaining

The HFIAS items show that adults, especially men, often absorb food shortfalls and that girls are slightly more exposed than boys even in "child-first" households. But survey frequencies cannot reveal how those decisions are negotiated, or whether adolescent girls feel able to ask for more food, refuse hawking, or stay in school during hungry seasons.

A natural complement to the baseline would be household-level case studies in high-insecurity LGAs in Katsina and Kaduna, combining:

- separate FGDs with adolescent girls and with caregivers; and
- a small set of in-depth interviews tracing how one household copes across a lean season.

These methods would make visible the trade-offs families make between schooling, hawking, and food and would help test whether AGILE's financial incentives are changing bargaining dynamics in ways the survey alone cannot capture.

4.4 Finding 4: School Infrastructure Reality Check, Only One School in Four Has Sufficient Classroom Seats

4.4.1 What Was Measured

The school survey captures binary and continuous items relating to five categories of school facility: classroom blackboards, drinking water availability, toilet provision (any toilet), girls' toilet provision (separate), and classroom seating capacity relative to the SS1 enrolment cohort. The seating-adequacy item (if_13_class_seats) is a binary derived measure: it is coded 1 if the school's total classroom seat count for SS1 is sufficient to accommodate the enrolled SS1 girl cohort, and 0 if not.

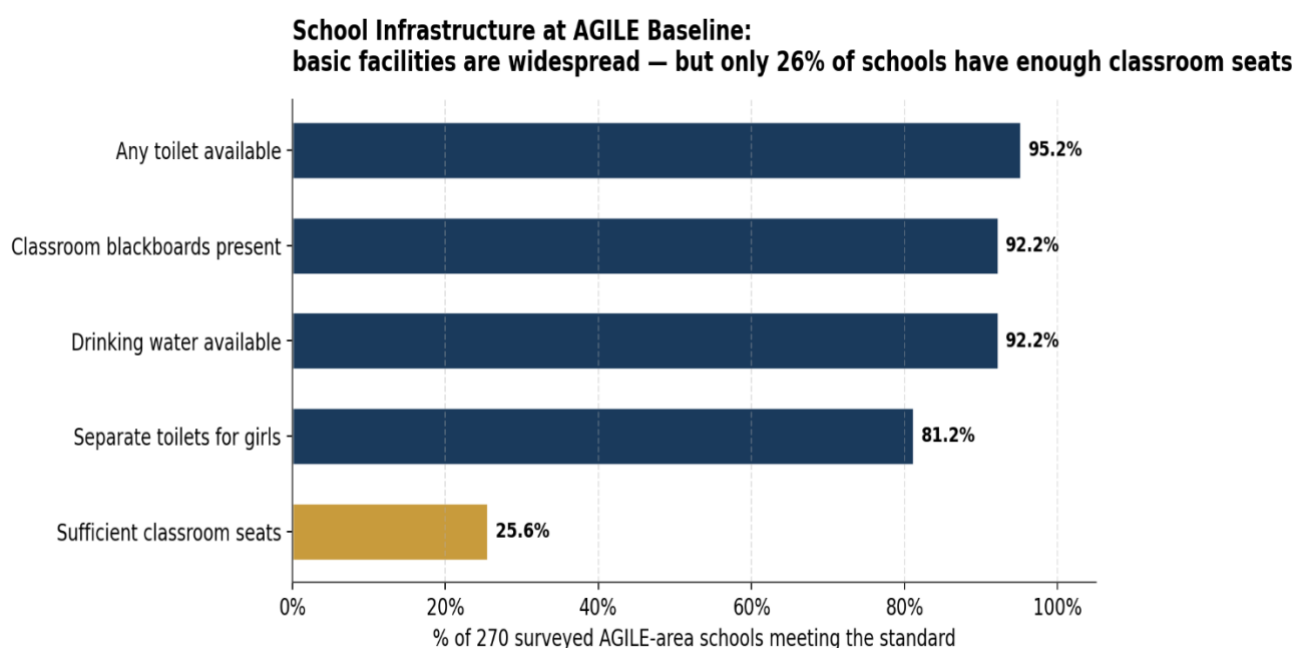
4.4.2 Results

Table 4.5, Percentage of Surveyed Schools Meeting Each Infrastructure Standard (N = 270 schools)

Infrastructure Standard	% of Schools Meeting Standard
Any toilet available	95.19
Classroom blackboards present	92.22
Drinking water available	92.22
Separate toilets for girls	81.15
Sufficient classroom seats for SS1 cohort	25.56

Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M), N = 270 schools. Note: separate girls' toilets computed on N = 260 schools reporting the item.

Figure 4. School infrastructure at AGILE baseline: % of 270 surveyed SS1 schools meeting each basic facility standard. (N = 270).



Source: Author's analysis of AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 (World Bank, NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M).

The pattern is distinctive and counter-intuitive relative to the prevailing narrative of Nigerian school infrastructure. For four of the five indicators, the majority of surveyed schools already meet the standard: 95 per cent have at least one toilet, 92 per cent have both blackboards and drinking water, and 81 per cent have separate toilet facilities for female students. These are not negligible baseline levels. If AGILE's Component 1 construction programme is calibrated primarily to close water, sanitation, and basic-amenity gaps, it may be investing in a distribution tail of approximately 5-20 per cent of schools with respect to those specific amenities.

The seating-adequacy indicator tells an entirely different story. Only 26 per cent of schools, roughly one in four, have sufficient classroom seats to accommodate their enrolled SS1 girls cohort. Three schools in

four have more enrolled girls than they have seats. In a school with an inadequate seat count, AGILE's enrolled beneficiaries cannot all sit during a lesson simultaneously. The physical learning environment constraint exists not in the walls or the roof or the toilet block, infrastructure elements that most of these schools already have, but in the most basic element of a functional classroom: a place to sit.

4.4.3 M&E Implication

AGILE's infrastructure indicators (Table 3.1, rows 6-7) count the number of classrooms constructed or rehabilitated. "Substantially rehabilitated" in this context encompasses structural repairs, roofing, ventilation, and typically the installation or replacement of sanitation and water infrastructure. The indicators do not capture whether the rehabilitated or newly built classrooms are equipped with sufficient furniture to seat the number of girls the school actually enrolls.

This is a gap with direct operational consequences. A school that meets AGILE's construction indicator criterion, having received a School Improvement Grant and completed rehabilitation of its physical structure, may still fail to provide a learning seat for every enrolled girl if the SIG disbursement did not include a furniture component. The baseline data suggest this is the modal state of affairs, not an edge case: 74 per cent of surveyed schools are in this condition.

The programme's theory of change for Component 1 runs: construct or rehabilitate - girls feel safe - girls stay enrolled - girls achieve learning outcomes. The seating-adequacy gap introduces a step that the theory misses: construct or rehabilitate - girl has no seat - girl stands or squats - engagement drops - absenteeism rises - the retention effect that Component 1 is meant to produce is partially undermined. No amount of social-norm change (Component 2) or financial incentive (Component 2 sub-component) can solve a girl's absent learning seat.

4.4.4 What Counts as the Binding Constraint

The phrase "binding constraint" has a specific technical meaning in the economics of development: it is the constraint that, if relaxed, produces the largest improvement in the outcome of interest. The infrastructure data in Table 4.5 suggest that the binding constraint in AGILE-area schools at baseline is not toilets (present in 95 per cent of schools), not water (present in 92 per cent), not blackboards (present in 92 per cent), and not even the absence of girls-only toilet facilities (absent in only 19 per cent). The binding constraint is seats. A construction programme that continues to prioritize structural rehabilitation over furniture provision will not solve the binding constraint, even as it satisfies its own indicator targets.

This finding does not argue against construction. It argues for a rebalancing of the SIG expenditure formula, or at minimum for the addition of a furniture and fitting sub-category to the SIG, and for the inclusion of a seating-adequacy item in the school survey instrument used at midline and endline. Without that measurement, the programme cannot track whether the seating gap is closing as construction outputs accumulate.

4.4.5 How Girls Experience Infrastructure: An Agenda for Qualitative Work

The seating data tell us that most SS1 girls do not have a guaranteed place to sit. They do not tell us how girls experience that constraint: who stands and who sits when seats are scarce, whether girls avoid school on days when classrooms are overfull, or how teachers manage overcrowded rooms.

School-based FGDs with girls in over-enrolled schools, triangulated with brief teacher interviews and classroom observations, could document:

- how seating shortages affect attention, participation, and absenteeism;
- whether girls perceive SIG-funded works as improving their daily reality; and
- what "minimum acceptable" classroom conditions look like from their perspective.

Those narratives would help SPIUs decide whether to reweight SIG guidelines toward furniture and fittings, and would give substance to the otherwise abstract notion of a "binding constraint".

5. WHAT THE INDICATORS DO AND DO NOT CAPTURE

5.1 The Gap Between Outputs and Theory of Change

The four findings presented in Section 4 speak to a structural feature of the AGILE Results Framework that is worth making explicit before turning to recommendations. The framework is oriented toward outputs, girls trained, classrooms built, incentives paid, GRM cases resolved, rather than toward the enabling conditions that determine whether outputs convert into outcomes. This is not unusual; output indicators are easier to measure, less subject to attribution problems, and more responsive to programme management. But a programme as large and as complex as AGILE, one that simultaneously addresses supply constraints, demand constraints, and social-norm constraints, needs at minimum a small set of enabling-condition indicators to triangulate whether its multiple pathways are actually open.

5.2 Finding-by-Finding Comparison

Digital literacy (Finding 1). The official framework commits to measuring the percentage of trained girls who demonstrate digital literacy after training. That is a legitimate outcome indicator. What it cannot tell us, without a parallel baseline on prior digital exposure, is whether the 55 per cent competency target reflects a genuine learning gain or a selection effect: that girls who already had device experience are disproportionately represented in the training cohort, while the most digitally excluded girls either self-select out of training or fall below the competency threshold because their starting point was near zero. The baseline data in Section 4.1 document the exposure landscape: only 6 per cent of enrolled girls have used a smartphone, 17 per cent have used any mobile phone. A pre-training intake survey that records this information for each cohort would transform the framework's digital-literacy indicator from an output count into a genuine learning-gain metric.

Caregiver aspiration (Finding 2). The official framework has no aspiration indicator at all. Component 2's social-norm change activities, the Madubi campaign, traditional-ruler advocacy, life-skills modules, have no measurable baseline against which programme managers or the World Bank Task Team Leader can assess whether norms are shifting. The baseline data in Section 4.2 provide that baseline for three states. The framework does not currently have a mechanism for midline aspiration tracking that would allow even a partial assessment of whether Component 2's substantial investment is producing the cognitive change it was designed to produce. The implementation review rated the programme Moderately Satisfactory; that rating would be better grounded if it were supported by aspiration-shift evidence rather than communication-reach evidence alone.

Food security (Finding 3). The official framework's financial-incentive indicator counts payments delivered. It does not ask whether the households receiving payments are the most food-insecure eligible households, or whether those payments reduce food insecurity for enrolled girls specifically. The baseline data in Section 4.3 reveal that approximately one household in five in the enrolled sample is food-insecure at baseline, with meaningfully higher prevalence in Katsina. A food-security targeting indicator, as simple as requiring that financial-incentive recipient households score above a defined HFIAS threshold at intake, would make the programme's poverty-targeting claim verifiable rather than assumed.

School infrastructure (Finding 4). The official framework counts classrooms built or rehabilitated. It does not ask whether those classrooms have seats. The baseline data in Section 4.4 show that 74 per cent of surveyed schools lack sufficient seating for their enrolled cohort. A framework that achieves its classroom-construction targets while the seating gap persists will have technically succeeded on its own terms while the binding infrastructure constraint for enrolled girls remains unresolved. A seating-adequacy item in the school survey, collected at midline and endline, would allow the programme to track whether SIG disbursements are closing this gap.

5.3 Why This Matters for Accountability

AGILE is, at US\$1.2 billion, among the largest commitments to girls' education in the world at this moment. The June 2025 Implementation Review Mission noted that three of five Year 5 PDO targets have been achieved or surpassed. That is a genuine achievement. But achievement on an incomplete indicator set can mask underperformance on unmeasured dimensions. If 55 per cent of trained girls demonstrate digital literacy, but that 55 per cent is disproportionately composed of girls who were already digitally familiar before training, the programme will have certified competency without having built capacity among its most excluded beneficiaries. If caregiver aspirations remain fixed at diploma-level in Katsina while the communication campaign generates large broadcast reach, the social-norm change investment will have achieved reach without impact. If financial incentives are distributed primarily through the most administratively accessible households rather than the most food-insecure, the programme will have delivered payments without targeting depth.

These are not hypothetical failure modes. They are well-documented challenges in large-scale social programmes, and they are the precise failure modes that a properly designed Results Framework prevents by measuring the right enabling conditions alongside output counts.

A final limitation is that this brief deliberately stays on the quantitative side of the line. It documents what girls, caregivers, and school heads **report** doing and experiencing, but it has no access to their narratives, beliefs, or internal trade-offs. We now know that a Kaduna caregiver is more likely than a Katsina caregiver to aspire to university, and that a Katsina household is more likely to have skipped meals last week, but we do not yet know how those facts are explained, justified, or contested within families and communities. Addressing that gap will require a parallel qualitative strand - focus group discussions, in-depth interviews, and school ethnography - designed to sit alongside the AGILE-IE quantitative work rather than replace it.

6. RECOMMENDATIONS

The following five recommendations are designed to close the measurement gaps identified in Sections 4 and 5. Each is scoped to be actionable within AGILE's existing administrative infrastructure, no recommendation requires a new survey instrument from scratch, and each builds on data already being collected in some form.

Recommendation 1: Add a Pre-Training Digital-Exposure Intake Form to the Digital-Literacy Training Protocol

Gap addressed: Section 4.1 (Finding 1, Digital Literacy Floor)

Proposed indicator: Percentage of digital-literacy training enrollees who have used each of the nine target device categories at least once prior to training, disaggregated by state

Rationale: The official framework's competency-demonstration indicator (55 per cent post-training) does not distinguish learning gain from prior-exposure advantage. A nine-item binary intake form, taking approximately three minutes to complete per trainee, would provide the prior-exposure denominator that makes the post-training competency indicator interpretable as a learning-gain metric.

Implementation pathway: The intake form should be appended to the existing training-enrolment MIS record for each trainee cohort. This requires no new data collection technology (the existing CAPI infrastructure or a paper form is sufficient) and no sampling strategy (it covers the full training population). State-level prior-exposure benchmarks from the AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023, reported in Table 4.1 of this brief, provide the cross-reference against which aggregate cohort intake scores can be validated.

Timeline: Operational before the first midline training cohort. Given that the midline survey is anticipated within the next eighteen months, the intake form should be piloted and validated within the next three months.

Measurable target (proposed): The programme should be able to report, at midline, the average learning gain (post-training competency score minus prior-exposure score at intake) for each state's cohort, disaggregated by device category. A target of a 30-percentage-point average learning gain for girls entering with zero or near-zero prior exposure would represent a meaningful programme contribution.

Recommendation 2: Incorporate a Caregiver Educational Aspiration Measure into the Midline and Endline Survey Instruments

Gap addressed: Section 4.2 (Finding 2, Caregiver Aspiration Gradient)

Proposed indicator: Distribution of caregiver educational aspirations for enrolled daughters across aspiration bands (up to SS3; vocational/diploma; bachelor's; master's or above), disaggregated by state

Rationale: Component 2's social-norm change activities have no measurable baseline against which to assess aspiration shift. The baseline aspiration distribution is now documented in Table 4.2 of this brief. The midline and endline surveys should repeat the same aspiration item (aa2_3_lvl_constrnt_educ or equivalent) on a representative subsample of caregivers from the original baseline sample to allow difference-in-differences estimation of aspiration change attributable to programme contact.

Implementation pathway: The question wording and response categories are already developed and tested in the baseline instrument. Repeating this item at midline requires only its inclusion in the caregiver survey question list, no new instrument design. IPA, which is responsible for the impact evaluation, would be the appropriate implementing partner for this recommendation in coordination with FME's NPCU.

Timeline: Inclusion in the midline caregiver survey instrument, which should be fielded approximately twenty-four to thirty months after baseline.

Measurable target (proposed): A statistically significant upward shift in the modal aspiration category in Katsina and Kano, from "diploma/NCE" toward "bachelor's degree", in communities with documented AGILE communication campaign exposure, relative to matched communities without such exposure. A 5-percentage-point shift in the share of caregivers aspiring to bachelor's level or above, in Katsina specifically, would represent meaningful progress against a very low baseline.

Recommendation 3: Establish a Food-Security Targeting Verification Measure for the Financial-Incentive Sub-Component

Gap addressed: Section 4.3 (Finding 3, Household Food Insecurity)

Proposed indicator: Percentage of financial-incentive recipient households that scored above the HFIAS moderate food-insecurity threshold at programme intake; and mean change in HFIAS score for recipient households between incentive intake and twelve-month follow-up

Rationale: The financial-incentive sub-component claims to reach the poorest enrolled households, but the Results Framework includes no food-security targeting criterion. The baseline data show that approximately one in five enrolled households is food-insecure at programme start. Without intake food-security screening, the programme cannot verify that its payments are reaching the most deprived, rather than the most administratively accessible, households.

Implementation pathway: A short HFIAS module (four to six items) should be integrated into the household registration form completed at financial-incentive enrolment. This is already a required administrative step, families must be registered and verified before receiving payments. Adding four to six food-security items to that registration form adds under five minutes to the intake process and generates a targeting-verification record for every recipient household. At twelve-month follow-up, the same module would be repeated on a random subsample of recipient households, enabling pre-post impact measurement.

Timeline: Integration into the household registration form should be completed before the next payment cycle in states currently enrolling new beneficiaries. States that have already made initial payments should add the module at the next scheduled beneficiary re-verification.

Measurable target (proposed): At least 70 per cent of financial-incentive recipient households should score at or above the HFIAS moderate food-insecurity threshold at intake, demonstrating that payments are genuinely concentrated among food-insecure households. At twelve-month follow-up, a target 20-percentage-point reduction in the proportion of recipient households scoring as severely food-insecure would represent a plausible impact of sustained financial-incentive payments.

Recommendation 4: Add a Classroom Seating-Adequacy Item to the Annual School-Level Infrastructure Verification

Gap addressed: Section 4.4 (Finding 4, Seating Gap)

Proposed indicator: Percentage of AGILE-supported schools in which classroom seat count meets or exceeds enrolled SS1 girl cohort size

Rationale: Three in four surveyed schools lack sufficient classroom seats for their enrolled SS1 cohort. This is the binding infrastructure constraint, yet it is invisible in the current Results Framework, which counts classrooms built but not seats per classroom. SIG disbursement verification visits, which already occur as part of the civil-works progress reporting process, should include a mandatory seating census: total seats in SS1 classrooms and current SS1 female enrolment. This single addition to the verification checklist would make the seating constraint visible in programme management data.

Implementation pathway: SPIU environmental and social officers already conduct civil-works site visits at defined intervals. Adding a seating census to the standard verification checklist requires no additional site visits, no additional personnel, and no new technology. The seating census item can be added as a single additional line on the existing verification form.

Timeline: Operational before the next SPIU verification cycle, which should occur within the next six months given that the midline survey is anticipated within eighteen months.

Measurable target (proposed): The programme should demonstrate, at the next annual infrastructure review, that the proportion of AGILE-supported schools meeting the seating-adequacy standard has increased from the 26 per cent baseline. A target of 50 per cent of schools meeting the standard at midline would represent meaningful progress against a severe baseline gap.

Recommendation 5: Establish a Gender-Disaggregated Intra-Household Resource-Allocation Indicator Linked to the Financial-Incentive Sub-Component

Gap addressed: Sections 4.3 and 5.2 (intersection of food-security and gender-differentiated impact)

Proposed indicator: At twelve-month follow-up, change in the proportion of financial-incentive recipient households reporting that adolescent girls "often" or "always" go without food when supplies run short, relative to matched control households

Rationale: The baseline data show that within food-insecure households, children are markedly more protected than adults, and that girls are very slightly more protected than boys (9.5 per cent of girls versus 13.5 per cent of boys experiencing 'often' or 'always' meal shortfalls). Whether AGILE's financial-incentive payments shift this allocation further in girls' favor, or whether they reduce overall household food insecurity in ways that benefit all members, is a theoretically plausible mechanism that the Results Framework does not currently track.

Implementation pathway: The food-security module recommended in Recommendation 3 already captures the intra-household frequency distribution by household member type. The gender-disaggregated child food-allocation items should be retained in both the intake and twelve-month follow-up forms, enabling a difference-in-differences analysis of whether financial incentives shift food allocation toward enrolled girls.

Timeline: Contingent on Recommendation 3 being implemented. If the food-security intake module is added to the next payment cycle, twelve-month follow-up data will be available within the midline evaluation window.

Measurable target (proposed): A statistically significant reduction in the proportion of recipient-household girls experiencing "often" or "always" meal shortfalls, relative to control households, would constitute measurable evidence that the financial-incentive mechanism is producing girl-specific intra-household resource-allocation improvements beyond simple household-level poverty reduction.

7. NOTES ON THE PROGRAMME'S DOCUMENTED ACHIEVEMENTS

This brief has been analytical and critical in tone, which is the appropriate posture for an independent M&E review. Before closing, it is important to situate the four gaps identified here within a programme that has also documented substantial achievement.

Enrolment of girls in secondary school in AGILE's participating states has grown from approximately 900,000 at project inception in 2020 to more than three million by May 2023, a more than tripling within three years. The evidence base for this figure comes from multiple sources: the TheCable reporting (May 2023), corroborated by FME's own project magazine (April 2023) and by the World Bank's June 2025 Implementation Review, which notes that three of five Year 5 PDO targets have been achieved or surpassed, including girls' enrolment and completion rates. This is a genuinely impressive implementation achievement in a challenging environment, accomplished despite significant insecurity constraints in Borno and other northern states, documented fraud challenges in Kebbi that required a project suspension, and the governance complexities of managing an eighteen-state programme across both federal and state administrative tiers.

The infrastructure programme has also produced concrete results: more than 5,000 classrooms constructed or rehabilitated project-wide by early 2023; more than 8,400 toilet units installed; solar-powered boreholes in states like Sokoto that previously had no reliable water access in schools. The Grievance Redress Mechanism, as documented in the GRM Manual (FME, 2022), is structurally sound and operationally comprehensive, with three-tier committee structures, dedicated GBV protocols, and quarterly Task Team reporting. Kano State's documented increase in Junior Secondary School gross enrolment ratio from 48 per cent to 67 per cent, and Senior Secondary from 38 per cent to 59 per cent, between 2021 and June 2025 (Kano State Education Log, 2025) represents a structural shift in educational access that, if sustained, will have lasting generational effects.

The argument of this brief is not that these achievements are insufficient or not worth celebrating. The argument is that they could be better accounted for, and that the gaps in the Results Framework identified here make it impossible to know with confidence why they are being achieved, for whom they are most pronounced, and which programmatic elements are driving the most impact. That knowledge is what allows a programme of AGILE's scale and ambition to improve its theory of change, allocate resources more precisely, and demonstrate not just reach but impact.

8. CLOSING THESIS

The central argument of this brief is stated in these three sentences.

AGILE's Results Framework measures what the programme does, girls trained, classrooms built, incentives paid, with adequate precision for output accountability. It does not adequately measure the conditions that determine whether those outputs convert into outcomes: whether trainees had the prior exposure to benefit from digital training, whether caregivers' aspirations for their daughters are rising, whether the households most in need of financial support are the ones receiving it, and whether girls in AGILE-supported schools actually have a seat in which to learn. Closing these measurement gaps before the midline survey is not a refinement at the margins of programme management, it is the precondition for knowing whether the world's largest gender-focused education investment in West Africa is achieving the transformation in girls' lives that it was designed to produce.

The baseline data presented in this brief, drawn from 8,223 adolescent girls, 8,007 caregivers, and 270 schools across Kaduna, Kano, and Katsina, are not definitive answers. They are precise starting points. A programme with US\$1.2 billion of public money and the ambition to reach 8.6 million girls has both the obligation and the capacity to build on them.

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10. DATA APPENDIX

A.1 Dataset Citation

World Bank Microdata Library. (2023). Nigeria, Adolescent Girls Initiative for Learning and Empowerment Impact Evaluation (NGA_2023_AGILE-IE_v01_M). World Bank Open Data. Public-use anonymized dataset. Accessed June 2025.

A.2 Variables Used in Analysis

Adolescent survey variables:

Variable Name	Description	Type
state	State code (18 = Kaduna, 19 = Kano, 20 = Katsina)	Categorical
dl3_2_mobilephone	Ever used mobile phone (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_1_internet	Ever used internet (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_6_online_search	Ever used online search (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_27_initiat_transac	Ever initiated a digital transaction (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_3_smartphone	Ever used a smartphone (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_21_shoponline	Ever shopped online (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_23_online_bankin	Ever used online banking (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_4_computer	Ever used a computer (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
dl3_5_tabletcomputer	Ever used a tablet computer (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
fs_1_skip_meal	Household skipped any meal in past 7 days (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary

Caregiver survey variables:

Variable Name	Description	Type
state	State code	Categorical
aa2_3_lvl_constrnt_educ	Caregiver's educational aspiration for adolescent daughter	Ordinal (1-11)
fs_1_skip_meal	Household skipped any meal in past 7 days	Binary
fs_3a_adultmen	Frequency adult men go without food when short (1-4, -555 = N/A)	Ordinal
fs_3b_adultwomen	Frequency adult women go without food when short	Ordinal
fs_3c_boys	Frequency boys (children) go without food when short	Ordinal
fs_3d_girls	Frequency girls (children) go without food when short	Ordinal

School survey variables:

Variable Name	Description	Type
state	State code	Categorical
if_12_class_blackboard	Classrooms have blackboards (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
if_14_drinkng_water	Drinking water available (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
if_16_toilet	Any toilet available (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
if_17_separate_toilet	Separate toilet facilities for girls (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary
if_13_class_seats	Sufficient classroom seats for SS1 cohort (1 = yes, 0 = no)	Binary

A.3 Reproducibility

The complete analysis, including all data-loading steps, variable recoding, percentage calculations, and chart production, is contained in the Jupyter notebook AGILE_Brief2_Analysis.ipynb, which is available in the accompanying zip archive alongside the four PNG chart files and this CSV. The notebook was executed on Google Colab (Python 3.10, pandas 2.x, NumPy 1.26, Matplotlib 3.8).

Anyone with access to the three constituent CSV files from the public-use AGILE-IE Baseline Survey 2023 dataset (downloadable from the World Bank Microdata Library upon registration) can reproduce all figures in this brief by uploading those files and running Cells 1-9 of the notebook in sequence.

A.4 Key Findings Numbers

The companion file `key_findings_numbers.csv` contains 83 rows of analysis-tagged, state-disaggregated percentage values covering all four analytical findings in this brief. Column structure:

- `analysis`: Analysis identifier (1_digital, 2_aspiration, 3_skip_by_state, 3_skip_by_member, 4_infra)
- `state`: State name or "All states" / "All"
- `item`: Descriptive label for the specific measure
- `value_pct`: Percentage value rounded to two decimal places

Selected rows are reproduced in the tables throughout Sections 4 and 5 of this brief. The complete file is available in the accompanying archive.